

Epoch-making run: Sydney

McLaughlin-Levrone became the first woman in nearly 40 years to crack 48 seconds in the 400 meters, running 47.78 in a historically fast one-lap race. AP

Area Records were set or equalled. There were also historic firsts: Samoa's Alex Rose (men's discus), Saint Lucia's Julien Alfred (women's 100m) and Uruguay's Julia Paternain (women's marathon) all claimed their nations' first World Championships medals. Tanzania's Alphonse Felix Simbu won his country's first-ever gold in the men's marathon.

Mondo Duplantis set his 14th world record in the pole vault, clearing 6.30m. Melissa Jefferson-Wooden of the USA completed a sprint treble in the 100m, 200m and 4x100m. Sydney McLaughlin-Levrone ran the second-fastest 400m in history – 47.78 – becoming the only athlete to win both the women's 400m and 400m hurdles title (having taken the latter in 2022). For Indian officials, Tokyo leaves questions. Did athletes peak too early? How wide is the gap between India's best and the world's? And is the nation's track and field reputation still tethered to the health of one athlete – Neeraj?

Naval Singh, however, prefers to look ahead. "Sachin did the best he could, considering he didn't have the best preparation for the 2025 season. We didn't really get an off-season. We have been competing right through 2024. But we will be preparing properly for next year. At the next World Championships, we want to be on the podium," he says.

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